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CRAVINGS

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THE KITCHEN WITCH

How Chef Arielle Faria channeled her ancestors and America's Test Kitchen to mold her craft

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PROFILE

The Rise *of the* Home Cook

Between ancestral recipes and intuition, Arielle Faria cooks with memory, instinct, and something that feels a little like magic.

BY SAM DECOTEAU

MARTHA'S VINEYARD, MA

Who made the mac & cheese?" A common question posed in black households regarding this staple side dish. A rite of passage, thholy grail of golden creamy noodles is only deemed worthy by a truly exceptional cook.

Amongst chefs like Kevin Belton or Jamie Oliver is the resurgence of the home chef. Since the pandemic, shows like MasterChef or Great British Bake Off highlight the shift in food culture toward the popularity and skill of the at-home cook. Amongst these home chefs is Arielle Faria, whose mac & cheese passes that ultimate test.

A well-crafted roux, at least three cheeses, an abundance of seasoning, and cavatappi pasta make for the most incredible mac & cheese. She credits her skills to intuition, witchy spells, and her ancestors' recipes handed down throughout the generations. If Faria had been around in the 1600s, she would've been burned at the stake for the food she conjures in the kitchen. Casting spells over her cauldron—ok, pots and pans—she blends together a list of tried and true recipes to create nostalgic and innovative dishes. "They call me the kitchen witch," she smirks. How else do you explain how good her food is?

ARIELLE FARIA
(the kitchen witch)

As a child, Faria's innate curiosity came from the often-uttered refrain, "Get out of my kitchen!" What wondrous things are happening that I can't be a part of? These once inane items miraculously turned into a multi-course feast for the family. Seeing the budding seed of passion, her great-grandmother Christine Reid invited Faira into her inner sanctum to explore. Edible, inedible, it didn't matter; Ms. Reid happily tried each creation as if it were manna from heaven, even if all it was was marmalade on crackers. The joy of receiving praise for her cooking established a lasting love for creating meals.

That early encouragement turned into her first meal for her family— a junior chicken a l'orange paired with roasted carrots at only 10 years old. "And you know, everything was cooked properly. I didn't kill anybody. So I was like... I like this. Everyone said it was great." This praise and validation is exactly what she looks for when she cooks today. Nothing warms her more than the utter silence, the only noise being the scrape of utensils on dishware. "I will sit there and watch people eat my food."

Faria grows pensive, thinking about Sesame Street recently being canceled and PBS losing funding due to the changing priorities of the new administration. "I didn't actually learn from my grandmothers. I learned from watching television and then just trying." For home chefs, it's essential to find joy in the cooking process. Faria finds warmth in the silence, appreciating the moment as they enjoy her dishes. Like many aspiring cooks, she learned from cooking shows on PBS—think Julia Child and Lydia Bastianich—that inspired her to bring these recipes into her kitchen—the heart of cooking lies in understanding recipes as tools.

PBS held cooking shows by Julia Childs and Lydia Bostianitch, inspiring Faria to strike out and make these same dishes at home. "If you follow a recipe and it doesn't come out right, it's one of two things: you missed something, or it's a bad recipe." Her go-to source was *Cook's Illustrated*. It is literally known for being *America's Test Kitchen*.

Recipes are the basis of cooking. How can these chefs communicate and translate their stories in ways the audience can take home? From there, Faria transforms these recipes into creations from her perspective. With roots in the Caribbean and Southern cuisine, Italian food isn't just Italian; it now includes nontraditional ingredients like chili peppers. She remembers innovative takes like Ming Tsai's ossobuco, which blends his Chinese culture with traditional Italian cuisine. "I had never experienced that kind of combination of flavors." It opened Arielle's eyes to thinking outside the box and evolving into an artist in the kitchen—reminding us that cooking is a canvas for culinary creativity.

"I didn't have much, so I made do with what was available and treated those ingredients *right*."

Food tastes better with love, which is not just a saying to Faria - it's real. She cares about the quality of her ingredients, her mise en place, and the size of the onions, celery, and carrots, as the smells waft up when they hit the hot oil. "I didn't have much, so I made do with what was available and took the time to treat those ingredients *right*. [You] have to care about the product. You're not just going through the motions. You are trying to achieve an explosion of flavor, a reaction, something! You have to care."

Remember the essence of Anton Ego from Ratatouille: it's not just about liking food; it's about loving it. If a dish doesn't excite you, why serve it? Take pride in your craft, whether it's your grandmother's kitchen or a Michelin-starred restaurant.

Ultimately, cooking is about sharing joy and creating memorable moments. As a home chef, focus on the quality of your ingredients and pay attention to the details—how you chop your vegetables and the scents that blossom when you cook them. Whether you're whipping up a casual family dinner or trying something new, take pride in knowing you're carrying on a tradition that brings happiness to those around you. It's an honor to witness others enjoy what you've created—embrace the honor of being a home chef.

